3.5 Werowocomoco, the Powhatan Capital

In 1607, Europe had long-established capital cities such as London, Paris, and Madrid. When the Jamestown colonists first met the Native American chief they called Powhatan, they visited him in an equally sophisticated capital.

MAIN IDEA In the 1600s, Werowocomoco was the capital of the Powhatan tribes. Today researchers are exploring its site to learn about the tribes and their interactions with English colonists.

SEAT OF POWER FOR A CHIEFDOM

It was in Werowocomoco (wayr-wuh-KAH-muh-koh) that John Smith first met Powhatan's daughter Pocahontas, who eventually married colonist John Rolfe. Smith would later tell a dramatic tale of being rescued by Pocahontas from certain execution at the hands of Chief Powhatan's warriors. Historians suspect the true story of the meeting was a little less exciting, but it nevertheless was a key moment in the relationship between the colonists and the Powhatan people.

The village of Werowocomoco must have presented a real contrast to the Jamestown Colony in 1607. While Jamestown had been built on swampy ground, Werowocomoco was built on bluffs above the Pamunkey River, which the Europeans later renamed the York River, in present-day Virginia.

The village had many geographical advantages. River bluffs and nearby creeks served as natural defenses against attackers. Nearby waterways were a source of drinking water and fish. The surrounding



Archaeologists and members of Virginia's Native American tribes spend long hours carefully excavating the Werowocomoco dig site adjacent to the York River.

Copyright 2025 Cengage Learning. All Rights Reserved. May not be copied, scanned, or duplicated, in whole or in part. Due to electronic rights, some third party content may be suppressed from the eBook and/or eChapter(s). Editorial review has deemed that any suppressed content does not materially affect the overall learning experience. Cengage Learning reserves the right to remove additional content at any time if subsequent rights restrictions require it.





CRITICAL VIEWING Excavated artifacts provide insight into the people who once inhabited a region. What do these nails from Werowocomoco reveal about the people who lived in this Native American village?

land was suitable for farming, and nearby forests provided wood for building and fires.

Archaeological evidence suggests that Virginia Indians had lived on the Werowocomoco site since around 8000 B.C. By the early 1600s, the village was the seat of power for Chief Powhatan. He ruled over a group of more than 30 Algonquian-speaking tribes spread out over more than 8,000 square miles around Chesapeake Bay.

EXPLORING WEROWOCOMOCO TODAY

Today, Werowocomoco's wealth lies in the knowledge it reveals about Powhatan society. In 1609, Chief Powhatan abandoned the village, and in time the location of Werowocomoco was forgotten. Then in 2003, researchers announced they had used evidence from historical maps and documents to pinpoint the village's location. Since then, archaeologists have been actively excavating the site.

Finding Werowocomoco has allowed researchers to learn not only about how Powhatan society evolved but also about the meeting of the English and Native American cultures that took place between 1607 and 1609. Archaeologists found a number of English artifacts that closely resembled lists of trade goods John Smith kept in his Jamestown journals. These included several copper-alloy items such as a pot, fragments of a spoon, and small beads. In order to enhance his importance among local tribes, Chief Powhatan had tried to maintain an exclusive trade in objects such as these with the English.

Within a few years, the English and the Powhatan would be at war. Werowocomoco preserves evidence that for brief but significant moments before the conflict, the two sides engaged in mutual bonds of trade and cultural exchange.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What types of items did the Powhatan and the Jamestown settlers trade with each other?
2. **MAKE CONNECTIONS** Think about what you learned about Jamestown in this chapter. In what ways did geography affect the relationship between Jamestown and Werowocomoco?
3. **MAKE GENERALIZATIONS** What purposes do exploring and preserving sites like Werowocomoco serve?

Copyright 2025 Cengage Learning. All Rights Reserved. May not be copied, scanned, or duplicated, in whole or in part. Due to electronic rights, some third party content may be suppressed from the eBook and/or eChapter(s). Editorial review has deemed that any suppressed content does not materially affect the overall learning experience. Cengage Learning reserves the right to remove additional content at any time if subsequent rights restrictions require it.